of a Lashkar commander who was killed during a military offensive in Bajaur. He had played no part in the insurgency against Pakistan, but some of his comrades engaged the military following his death.[120]

Lashkar remained more cohesive than other militant groups and its cadres more disciplined, but freelancing increased in 2006–2007.[121] Whether as trainers, explosives experts or tacticians, Lashkar's members were considered among the best in Pakistan. Some began selling their expertise or skills, either on a consistent basis as 'consultants' or in an ad hoc manner for specific attacks.[122] Others were motivated more by ideological conviction and frustration at the leadership's willingness to toe the state's line despite a series of perceived betrayals: Musharraf's willingness to ally with America in 2001; the crackdown [albeit selective] on jihadi outfits thereafter; the army's entrance into the Tribal Areas to root out al-Qaeda and other foreign fighters; and the decision to scale back the Kashmir jihad. The storming of the Lal Masjid was viewed as the final betrayal. This event had an even greater impact on Deobandi militants because of their connection to the Lal Masjid, but Lashkar's cadres were not immune. For example, David Headley suggests this episode contributed to his becoming 'distanced' from the leadership. He saw current colleagues, such as Abdur Rehman Syed, and former ones, like Haroon and his brother Khurram, fighting a clear battle against 'the Crusaders' in Afghanistan. Meanwhile the Pakistani government appeared confused and compromised. As he described it, Headley began to understand that Syed, Haroon and Khurram were engaged in a different type of battle from Lashkar leaders, who continued to prioritize Kashmir, abjure attacks against the state and work with the ISI.[123] Haroon and Khurram had split from Lashkar in 2003, and by the latter years of the decade were working with Ilyas Kashmiri, whose 313 Brigade was close to al-Qaeda and responsible for several attacks in Pakistan from 2007 onwards. But they also kept in touch with members of their former organization, thereby influencing some Lashkar cadres, as well as serving as yet another nodal point for those who wished to access Kashmiri's outfit or through it al-Qaeda.

Lashkar was thriving as a social welfare provider and remained Pakistan's most reliable proxy against India, which continued to be the group's primary enemy. Its leadership was committed to the cause and retained influence in the organization, despite their close ties with the ISI. However,